Tuesday, January 17, 2023

It's easy to shout "enough!" when ensconced in California. But it has become impossible for me, at ninety plus, to fly safely from here to Tel Aviv (fifteen hours there and sixteen hours back). Yet Orna and I cannot think of anything else. We scrutinize the daily news in Hebrew, we dissect it, we chew it, we swallow it, and we vomit. It reminds me of the German film with Curd Jürgens (*Des Teufels General*) about the disenchanted Nazi pilot Ernst Udet in which, at some point, Udet declares that one cannot eat as much as one would like to throw up. Somehow the sentence stayed with me over the years and here it is, handy again. Udet apparently committed suicide in 1941.

Well, we aren't so far along yet, but how will this end? Last week Netanyahu's docile justice minister, Yariv Levin, unveiled bills that would allow the government to control the appointment of judges and restrict the Supreme Court's ability to strike down legislation. Who could have imagined that in Israel in 2023, a prime minister would try to overturn the whole legal system with the help of a tenuous ultra-right-wing and ultrareligious coalition, to escape three indictments for fraud, bribery, and breach of trust? Mass demonstrations have started against the government and its plans, but will they be enough to compel Netanyahu to backtrack? And if the coalition does not give in, and no new elections are in sight, what then?

This diary is open-ended. For the time being, it is just my private chronicle of an ongoing drama that will either lead to a celebration of the victory of democracy or an admission that the vibrant country I lived and worked in for decades is dead; that something else, something unacceptable, has taken its place.